Yellow in cultures and traditions

Yellow is a colour that in history has been a crown, a badge of **shame** and a vest of protest. **The same colour, opposing stories.** Let us look attentively and gently at a few places, because some of these stories are **painful**.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how yellow is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image.

Yellow in different cultures

China

In imperial China yellow had a prominent position. Under the Qing dynasty the colours of court dress determined rank and belonging to the imperial circle. Bright yellow belonged to the highest members of the imperial family; other shades had their designations too.

So it was not only a question of whether something matched someone's eyes. Clothing told you who stood before you and what place they had in the social order.

Here yellow is connected with authority, exceptionality and standing.

For your own reflection it offers a different image than a cheerful dandelion. It can recall **dignity** and the right to take your place.

At the same time it shows how the meaning of a colour is created by society. The power of imperial robes lay not only in the shade but also in the rules, ceremonies and power of its wearer.

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India

At the festival of Vasant Panchami, linked with the arrival of spring and the worship of the goddess Saraswati, yellow has a significant place. It appears in clothing and festive decoration. Saraswati is associated with learning, music and the arts.

Yellow here can carry an image of awakening and openness to the new.

For our guide the connection of **joy** and discovery is interesting. Learning does not have to be only something that must be mastered correctly. It can also be pleasant exploring.

You **can** set aside a yellow notebook for things that interest you. Without every interest having to become a course, a certificate or a business plan within a week.

Thailand

In the traditional Thai assigning of colours to days, yellow belongs to Monday. From this comes its use at some royal celebrations connected with a monarch born on a Monday.

Yellow clothing in such a setting can express belonging and **respect**.

At first glance you see a colour. Only knowing the custom shows why so many people suddenly have it.

That is a good reminder for everyday life. **Not every colour choice says something about mood. Sometimes it expresses belonging, tradition or a shared event.**

The Christian Middle Ages

Medieval Europe perceived yellow in two ways. Thanks to its similarity to gold it had a good reputation and appeared in heraldry.

In the late Middle Ages, though, it also acquired a dark side. Judas, who betrayed Jesus, appears in paintings more and more often in yellow clothing. Yellow then began to be linked with **envy** and betrayal.

The same colour could thus at the same time mean light and **shame**, depending on who it was put on.

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Yellow in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at yellow **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and a source of inspiration, not a healing guide.

Traditional Chinese medicine

In the system of five elements yellow is linked with earth. To this circle belong **the spleen and stomach**, the taking in of food and its transformation into what nourishes a person.

The names of organs here denote traditional functional circles. It is not the same description as in modern anatomy.

Earth is also linked with the period of late summer and with the transitions between seasons. Imagine a ripe field, the harvest and the moment when what has grown provides nourishment.

In this view yellow is not merely a prompt to activity. It is also a question of what you actually live on.

Everyone has enough. And you?

You know what everyone needs. You shop, arrange, listen, remind. At work you catch a problem before the others. At home you think about what else to do.

But you eat between doors yourself and put off pleasant things until the time when nothing is needed.

You **do not have to** have a family to recognise yourself in this. **You can** be long-term adapting to work, customers, parents or the idea that you must manage everything without help.

Care easily becomes one-way traffic.

The theme of earth also recalls receiving. Of food, support, rest, company and ordinary interest in you.

When worries keep coming back

In traditional interpretations earth also has a place for brooding. For everyday life **you can** notice the difference between thinking that leads to a decision and a worry that keeps going round in circles.

You can use yellow for a simple distinction. On one yellow sheet write what you **can** really do today. Put the other notes aside.

The point is not to heal the spleen with a piece of paper. The point is to stop demanding of yourself that everything be solved at once.

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Simple tips

Food. Take your favourite yellow bowl and really sit down. If you link it with **well-being**, it can help create a pleasant start to a moment for yourself. Nourishment, though, is determined by the food, not by its colour match with the bowl.

Space. Try a butter or ochre detail by the place where you rest. A soft fabric and a warm shade may be more pleasant than a sharp lemon on a large area.

Making. Try yellow with clay, ochre or brown. If earthiness delights you, this combination may be closer to you than a radiant yellow with black.

Receiving. When someone offers you help, **notice** your first answer. You **do not have to** automatically say “I can manage”. Sometimes accepting support is exactly what long-term giving needs to be topped up with.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda-inspired work with colours starts from the qualities of warmth, cold, **lightness**, heaviness, movement and stability. Colour recommendations differ between authors.

For this guide it is useful to watch whether a certain form of yellow pleasantly enlivens you or adds more intensity.

Vata · when there is a lot of everything and nothing stops

Vata is traditionally linked with movement and changeability.

For colour self-reflection imagine a day full of moving about, messages and things in progress. At such a moment a soft butter, ochre and familiar natural materials may be more pleasant to you than neon yellow patterns.

Try a warm fabric, a simple setting and one activity. Yellow here can accompany **cosiness**. It does not have to push you.

Pitta · when determination turns into pressure

Pitta is linked with fire and intensity.

When you are already **irritated**, competitive or strict with yourself, **you may** feel like toning down the striking surroundings too.

Try less rich yellows, more free space or the company of a colour that you yourself perceive as calmer. For example muted greens.

There is no need to drive yellow out of the house. Sometimes it is enough for it to stop being in charge of the shift.

Kapha · when there is too much stability

Kapha is traditionally linked with earth, water and stability.

For your own reflection imagine a period when everything is familiar, **comfortable** and a little without movement. A more striking yellow detail can be a welcome change, if it delights you.

Put a yellow flower in a place you walk past without noticing. **Try** a lighter textile. Take something on a walk that feels alive to you.

A colour prompt can accompany change. By itself it neither determines nor treats a dosha.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

In lectures at ETH in Zurich he linked colours with the functions of the psyche. Of intuition he said “Intuition is gold or yellow, because it is felt as radiant and shining.” Red for him belonged to feeling, blue or white to thinking and green to sensory perception. In the mandalas of the patient Kristine Mann he described yellow as meaning intuition, and wrote of gold that it expresses sunlight, value, even divinity.

How it relates to the colour yellow. Yellow may remind you. Trust the flash that came to you. Intuition is not something that can be proved. It is a hunch that comes from somewhere inside.

What you can take from it. When you are in your head and analysing everything, yellow in the form of flashes helps. **Write down the first idea, do not explain it**. When on the contrary you live only in hunches and finish nothing, green (the senses, the body) or blue (thinking) may do you good.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. Yellow is traditionally linked with the element of **earth** and with the centre. In the map of the house called the bagua the centre, northeast and southwest belong to earth. In a home yellow is therefore often the colour of **stability**, **warmth** and **the shared table**. **Sources differ.**

Yellow is like a spice

A little can bind the whole together, a large quantity determines the taste of everything else.

Before you paint a whole room, hold up a larger sample or a yellow fabric and look at it in the morning, afternoon and evening. Notice whether the space feels closer to you, or whether your gaze keeps returning to one spot that is beginning to keep you busy.

Simple tips

- **Want more light?**
  Add one yellow piece where you will see it every day.
- **Want more calm?**
  Choose butter, vanilla or sand and leave the rich one just for a detail.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, cream, green or more free space.
- **Want more ideas?**
  Put a yellow notebook or notes where you think and plan nothing with it.

And above all. Before you repaint a whole room, try **a throw**, **a fabric** or a larger colour **sample**. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Yellow always cheers you up.

TRUTH A soft butter and vanilla, yes. A rich lemon can tire the eyes and in a small room feel almost insistent.

MYTH Yellow is a colour just for children.

TRUTH Mustard, ochre and golden are adult and muted. In a children's room a gentle one is usually better than a garish one.

MYTH A yellow room is always lighter.

TRUTH Soft shades reflect light, but a rich yellow can feel heavy. The direction of the windows and the light matter too, not just the colour.

What yellow works well with

- **Wood, linen and cream** soften a bright yellow and give it a natural texture.
- **Clay, ochre and brown** support an earthy impression. When all the shades are muted and dark, though, the whole can feel tired.
- **Green** recalls leaves and flowers. Lemon with a fresh green will be livelier than butter with sage.
- **Blue** brings a stronger temperature contrast. It can create a fresh whole, but also a hard contrast.
- **Black** strongly emphasises yellow. On a small detail it can be impressive, but in large contrasting patterns it already recalls signage that wants you to keep watching out.
- **Grey and white** A cleaner, calmer impression. Yellow easily stands out against them.

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Elements

In feng shui the elements are related to one another.

- **Fire creates earth**
  Terracotta, orange and warm reds warm yellow through.
- **Earth supports metal**
  White, grey and brass add restraint to yellow.
- **Wood pulls earth in**
  Green adds liveliness, but watch the proportion of the two colours.
- **Earth holds water**
  Symbolically blue and black belong here, which calm or cool yellow.

In the traditional cycle of five elements fire supports earth and earth supports metal. That is why symbolic designs add fiery or metallic elements to earthy yellows. But into a real room more than a table comes. A yellow linen curtain, a yellow plastic chair and a brass lamp have a different surface, reflection and overall impression. The practical question is therefore whether the room holds you pleasantly, or is already heavy, sharp or overcrowded.

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Feng shui room by room

What works – what to watch for – a simple tip.

Living room

What works. Yellow cushions, an armchair, a picture or flowers add **liveliness** to a calmer base. Butter and ochre feel cosier than a sharp lemon, especially next to cream, wood and muted green.

What to watch for. When you let yellow take over the sofa, curtains and wall, you may no longer feel pleasant warmth but the constant presence of one colour. Especially in a room into which the sun shines strongly.

A simple tip. Leave **one striking piece** and calmer materials around it. If you then rest better, the change of quantity made sense. A living room can be sunny without having its own heatstroke all year round.

Kitchen and bathroom

What works. In the kitchen yellow ceramics, a tablecloth or a smaller area on the wall connect with food, butter and shared meals. Butter and golden feel **kind**. In the bathroom a towel or ceramics in a sandy yellow next to white and wood is enough.

What to watch for. A sharp yellow next to a large amount of red and gloss can give the impression that something is always going on. At the mirror, moreover, the colour of the room meets how you perceive your own skin. Yellow-tinted light also distorts the look of food.

A simple tip. Try **a tablecloth, a bowl or a towel** first. Notice whether the space invites you to stay, or is so busy that you want to get everything done and leave.

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Bedroom

What works. A soft butter, vanilla or sandy yellow, or yellow in a small pattern, can be pleasant if you link it with **warmth and softness**. Start with bedding or a throw that you can easily swap.

What to watch for. Large rich areas and sharp contrasts can feel too lively in a room where you want to wind down in the evening. Look at the sample under a lamp too, because a tender yellow in the daytime can feel richer in the evening. The colour of a wall is not a treatment for insomnia.

A simple tip. Put a yellow throw on the bed and watch your impression for several evenings. Do you feel like snuggling in, or does the room feel **ready for a morning meeting**? Choose a gentler shade or a smaller area accordingly.

Children's room

What works. Yellow can accompany a creative corner, pictures or individual pieces of furniture, for example a box for building blocks or a small table. A child **can choose** which form is pleasant to them.

What to watch for. A whole room does not have to be richly yellow just because it is meant to feel cheerful. A child looks for fun in it during the day and is meant to fall asleep in it in the evening. Yellow by itself does not explain restlessness, and a different paint will not guarantee falling asleep on command.

A simple tip. Separate the livelier place for play from the **calmer surroundings of the bed**. By the bed try fewer contrasts and fewer objects. A child does not need to fall asleep in the middle of a graphic design for a children's festival.

Study

What works. Yellow can mark a place for ideas, a noticeboard or one important thing. In a studio it brings individuality. Try **one yellow detail** by work in progress and leave the surroundings in warm grey, cream and wood.

What to watch for. Everything highlighted means nothing highlighted. A rich and bright yellow can tire the eyes and distract. If you paint, photograph or judge shades, a large rich surrounding also influences how you perceive other colours.

A simple tip. Leave yellow for ideas and **a more neutral surface** for the work itself. During long concentration compare a sharp lemon with a muted ochre and choose next to which it is easier to work.

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Hall and entrance

What works. A smaller yellow picture or a light yellow detail can be **a personal welcome**. The benefit is a pleasant first look, something that delights you before you start dealing with put-down bags and post.

What to watch for. A yellow coat of paint does not create daylight where there is none. Under an unsuitable lamp the shade can look dirty or greenish. Gloss moreover strengthens the light that is often missing in a hall.

A simple tip. Try a sample directly under the light you will use. Does the entrance welcome you, or does **the first look shout** at you?

Ask yourself

“Why do I want yellow at home? What is it meant to bring me, light, warmth, or appetite?”

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